

Old Testament: The Three-Watch System

The Hebrew night was divided into three equal segments of approximately four hours each, calculated from sunset to sunrise.

Watch	Name	Time Frame (Approx.)	References
First Watch	The Beginning of Watches	6:00 PM – 10:00 PM	Lamentations 2:19
Second Watch	The Middle Watch	10:00 PM – 2:00 AM	Judges 7:19
Third Watch	The Morning Watch	2:00 AM – 6:00 AM	Exodus 14:24, 1 Samuel 11:11

OT Highlights

- **Judges 7:19:** Gideon's surprise attack on the Midianites occurred at the **beginning of the middle watch**, capitalizing on the changing of the guards.
- **Exodus 14:24:** The Lord looked unto the host of the Egyptians through the pillar of fire and of the cloud during the **morning watch** to trouble them.

New Testament: The Four-Watch System

Under Roman occupation, the Jewish people adopted the Roman military division of the night into four watches, each lasting roughly three hours.

Watch	Name	Time Frame (Approx.)	References
First Watch	Even	6:00 PM – 9:00 PM	Mark 13:35
Second Watch	Midnight	9:00 PM – 12:00 AM	Luke 12:38; Mark 13:35
Third Watch	Cockcrowning	12:00 AM – 3:00 AM	Mark 13:35
Fourth Watch	Morning	3:00 AM – 6:00 AM	Matthew 14:25, Mark 13:35

NT Highlights

- **Matthew 14:25:** Jesus walked on the sea to reach His disciples during the **fourth watch of the night**.
- **Mark 13:35:** Jesus explicitly lists all four watches when commanding His followers to watch for His return: "**Watch ye therefore: for ye know not when the master of the house cometh, at even, or at midnight, or at the cockcrowing, or in the morning.**"